



Beyond the range: The violin is a recent addition to Manu's range of interests. She's also been taking classes in *kathak* and horse riding.

RITU RAJ KONWAR

went to so many countries and did not even go out of my room and the shooting range. I should have tried to enjoy different countries, cultures, and atmospheres," she says.

She does that more consciously now. "My last international competition was at the ISSF World Cup in Granada. The day after my competition ended was my birthday. I didn't really have any friends with me, so I just decided to roam around the city by myself. I went to the castle and saw the flamenco dancers. I watched a movie in Spanish without any subtitles. I didn't understand anything, but it was fun," she says.

While Manu is more balanced,

matured, and has regained her passion for the sport, some of the anger Rana remembers has not completely disappeared. Manu says, "Sometimes I'll just punch things, throw things, break things. But things like that will happen much more rarely now. But it's spectacular when it does happen. Just about a month ago, I was really disappointed after a training session that just didn't go well. It was just not a good day.

"So many things piled up one on top of the other that I just couldn't take it. And I punched a wall at the range. Luckily I didn't break a knuckle, but it still turned bright red. I didn't tell Jaspal sir for many days, and then finally when he saw that red mark on my knuckle, he asked me what was going on. I pretended I had this pain in my wrist or my hand. Now he'll tease me about it. If I ever start to get angry, he'll ask me if I plan on punching a wall."

As she heads to the Paris Olympics, Manu knows just how easy it would have been for her to not be a part of the Indian team. Tokyo claimed several of India's most talented shooters. Apurvi Chandela, who set a world record in the build-up to Tokyo, has disappeared from the scheme of things; as has Asian Games medallist Abhishek Verma.

Perhaps the biggest loss has been that of Saurabh Choudhary, who broke the world record in the qualification round of the Olympics but then crashed out early in the finals. While Manu had worn her misery on her sleeve, Saurabh had seemed the more composed shooter and the one who was more likely to return to the Olympics in three years' time. Instead, he could barely find a

place in the national team. A bitter dispute with his long-term coach Amit Sheoran has still not been resolved. He failed to qualify for the World Championships, Asian Games, and even the Olympic qualifiers in Bhopal. A brief return to the World Cup at Rio last year saw him fail to make even the finals.

As someone who herself came close to the brink, Manu empathises with her former teammate. "Saurabh, according to me, was the finest shooter I have ever seen in my life. It was a shocker that he hasn't even been able to make it to the Olympic trials. I think that he should have been given another chance. Maybe he might still come back. But if you don't give him a chance, he will be lost," she says.

For now, though, she will have to focus on herself. All her learning, improvement, and maturity will pay off in two months at Châteauroux. Manu knows this as well. "The goal is not to become the youngest two-time Olympian. The goal is something bigger — the Olympic gold. That's what every shooter is going for. I just look at it as an opportunity. I'm going to the Games, I'm representing my country, and I have to be ready and do my best. I think things will be different this time. I don't think I'll be intimidated as much," she says.

As the clock ticks down to the start of the Olympic Games, Manu is looking to wrap up another accomplishment — a pitch-perfect rendition of *Jana Gana Mana*.

The hope for the rest of the nation, though, is that in the shooting range at Châteauroux, it will be the stadium speakers instead that will play the Indian national anthem.